

COURT LIFE IN Kyoto

HEIAN-ERA JAPAN

The Heian period (794–1185) saw Japan break away from China's influence to establish a distinctly Japanese way of life. The era is celebrated for its poetry, art, and literature, and female poets played a central role in what became a golden age of Japanese culture. Women writers of the period, untrained in Chinese, wrote in Japanese—the language of the people. The work of female poets and their observations of daily life were therefore the texts that became most widely known, and heralded some of Japan's great literature.

Politics of marriage

Court marriages in the Heian capital of Kyoto were arranged, and elite women were instrumental in the associated marriage politics. Women of the courtier upper class stayed with their own families after marriage; husbands and wives either lived separately or the wife's family would adopt the husband as a son. This meant that Heian women could inherit property, unlike in societies where couples settled with the husband's family. Only Japanese men could be polygamous but, if discreet, women could take lovers. They could also petition for divorce and remarry. Women

were fully involved in raising children, and ran their own households if married to a noble or government official. Aristocratic families used the marriage of their daughters to further their political position, notably within the Fujiwara clan who married their daughters into the Imperial House of Japan and produced many emperor sons. Daughters of court officials and lesser nobles could advance their status by becoming concubines of high-ranking noblemen.

Women who could write elegant calligraphy or recite poetry attracted many admirers. Physical beauty was also important; practices such as whitening the face with powder (*oshiroi*), blackening the teeth (*ohaguro*), painting the mouth small and red, and removing the eyebrows to redraw them higher on the forehead (*hikimayu*) are described by Heian women writers. *Ohaguro* had become a custom during the Nara period (710–794).

Initially, the practice was used to indicate that a girl from an aristocratic family had reached puberty, and in her later years that she was married. On a superficial level, *ohaguro* was thought to enhance sex appeal.

Writers and leaders

Many Heian literary works throw light on the lives of noblewomen and courtesans at the Kyoto court, the most famous being *The Tale*

Heian's most
important
writers were
women between
the years
**950-
1050**

◀ Folk heroine

Japanese 12th-century heroine Kesa Gozen, pictured in a domestic scene, having washed her hair. Kesa sacrificed her life to protect her family's honor, and the story is told in a text that reflects the morals of the period.

